This chilled soup will always go down well on a hot summer's day. Fresh-tasting and with just the right amount of acidity, it can be enjoyed for lunch or dinner.

beet and tomato soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS 3 HRS CHILLING **COOK** 55 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

6 tbsp olive oil, plus extra to garnish
½ head garlic, coarsely chopped
1 large onion, coarsely chopped
4 celery ribs, coarsely chopped
1 bulb fennel, coarsely chopped
1lb 2oz (500g) very ripe plum tomatoes, coarsely chopped
1lb 2oz (500g) very ripe beefsteak tomatoes, coarsely chopped
9oz (250g) cooked beets, coarsely chopped
2 tbsp freshly chopped basil (stems reserved), plus 6 sprigs, to garnish
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1¾oz (50g) red, yellow, or pink baby beets, to garnish
1 tbsp chives, with blossoms if available, to garnish
4oz (115g) red, yellow, or orange cherry tomatoes, to garnish
crème fraîche, to garnish (optional)

1 Preheat the oven to 400˚F (200˚C). In a large, heavy saucepan over low heat, cook the garlic, onion, celery, and fennel in the oil, stirring, for 6–8 minutes. Add the tomatoes, beets, and basil stems and season. Barely cover with water, bring to a boil, then place, uncovered, in the oven for 40 minutes.

2 Transfer to a blender and process until smooth, adding a little water if necessary. Pass through a strainer, pushing as much as you can through with the back of the ladle. Season, then chill in the fridge for at least 3 hours.

3 Cook the baby beets in boiling salted water for 20–25 minutes or until tender, then drain, cool, and peel. Trim the ends, then halve or quarter, depending on size. Season and stir in half the chopped basil, half the chives, and a drizzle of oil. Halve and season the cherry tomatoes.

4 Stir the soup well, check the seasoning, and half-fill six chilled bowls. Spoon the baby beets and cherry tomatoes into the center of each bowl, then garnish with a drizzle of olive oil or a generous scoop of crème fraîche, the basil sprigs, and the rest of the chives, snipped.